



2026 IDA Case Competition

Defining Service Areas for Mobile Food Pantries

Student teams plan one month of mobile food pantry service across five states, choose the service area boundaries for each hub, and defend the recommendation with real data.

CASH PRIZES

\$150 per member for the first place team, **\$100 per member** for second, and **\$50 per member** for third.

The case

A fictional five-state food-access coalition runs twenty mobile pantries from fixed hubs across Alabama, Florida, Georgia, Mississippi, and Tennessee. Its members disagree about the service area boundaries for the hubs, so the case asks one question, i.e., whether a pantry may serve only the counties near its hub, anywhere in its own state, or anywhere in the five states.

What each team delivers

Each team builds five validated monthly route plans, compares them on reach, service, and travel, and recommends one option. The data are real, i.e., American Community Survey economic need across 11,925 census tracts, 940 candidate service sites, and county-level grocery mobility aggregates.

Any method is acceptable, i.e., optimization, a heuristic, or a spreadsheet workflow. Every plan must pass a validator provided with the case materials, and proof of optimality is not required.

The submission

Submissions are due by 11:59 p.m. Central Time on October 28, 2026, and each team submits one email that includes a slide deck as one PDF file, a link to a recorded presentation, and the five route files described in the case materials. No written report is required. Presentations are 15 minutes, and every team member speaks.

How judges score

Dimension	Weight
Analytical validity	30%
Decision quality	25%
Equity and responsibility	20%
Robustness	15%
Communication	10%

The case materials will include the competition data and starter software for preliminary analysis, and the software runs on Linux, Windows, and macOS. Generative artificial intelligence is permitted with disclosure.

The location and start time of the November 13 presentations will be announced by November 4. Questions about the case, the rules, and logistics should be sent to freem028@ua.edu.

How to register

Students interested in competing should send one email to the address below by 11:59 p.m. Central Time on **October 7, 2026**.

freem028@ua.edu

The email should use the subject line **"IDA Case Competition"** and include the team name, the college each member represents, and the name and email address of every member.

Registered teams receive the case materials and a download link by email on October 7.

Who may enter

Teams can have up to three currently enrolled University of Alabama undergraduate or graduate students from any college. Mixed undergraduate and graduate teams are allowed, and a person may join only one team.

Key dates

2026	Milestone
Oct 7	Registration closes and materials go out
Oct 28	Submissions due
Nov 4	Finalists notified
Nov 13	Three finalists present at the Business Analytics Summit

Live question session dates are announced with the case materials on October 7.